

FIT Position Paper on the Wellbeing of Professional Translators, Interpreters and Terminologists (extract)

Several recent developments and rapid changes in the translation environment are increasingly challenging the mental health and wellbeing of professional translators and interpreters: falling rates in a competitive market, decrease in quality in the provision of services, de-professionalization, de-humanization resulting from the advent of portals automating project management, the emergence of artificial intelligence –which has resulted in a paradigm shift in terms of customer requirements–, and the fragmentation of roles, amongst other factors. These factors affect different segments of the profession in varied ways: some industry segments are experiencing growth (e.g., localisation services), while others have shrunk (e.g., routine business translation). According to the European Language Industry Survey (ELIS, 2023), successive crises, global inflation, and recent developments in language technology and artificial intelligence have reshaped the industry landscape. These changes have led translators and interpreters to express increasing negativity regarding fair remuneration and work-life balance.

While translation and interpreting services continue to be in demand, the rapidly changing environment requires language professionals to develop a strong set of soft skills, such as stress resilience and self-motivation, and to have the ability to leverage their strengths to be successful in today's world. For example, professional translators must be willing to adapt and use their creativity to develop business models that make the most of the latest technologies. They must accept that there will be less work in some areas of activity and proactively seek new opportunities (Downie, 2016). Professional interpreters will need to find ways to assert their value and autonomy if engaging in digital platform work, or other forms of supply-demand intermediation, where existing power dynamics can serve to perpetuate unethical practices (Giustini, 2024). Some language professionals will more readily embrace change than others, and it is essential to prepare all future professional translators and interpreters for a turbulent market in order to maintain the ongoing sustainability of this workforce.

Factors relating to (1) the wider environment in which they work, and (2) the core or central aspects of their job, all have the potential to impact the mental and physical health of translators and interpreters, their wellbeing, and the quality of their work. As context shapes experience, how professional linguists feel, think, and behave can be influenced by several situational factors, including –but not limited to– social relationships (e.g., with clients), situational goals (e.g., competitive environment), physical ergonomics (e.g., intensive use of technology tools), and structural factors (e.g., pay rates). While some professionals thrive within their environments, contextual and systemic factors can lead others to experience isolation, pressure, uncertainty, dissatisfaction and ethical stress, amongst other impacts.

In itself, the work content that language professionals engage with (texts, speeches, audiovisual material, and other outputs) can also affect their mental and physical health, for instance, by triggering specific emotions, straining or putting pressure on their bodies, or making additional cognitive demands (Ferreira et. al., 2020). While some derive great satisfaction from their work (e.g., Ruokonen et al., 2020), for others, the work may at times be repetitive, lead to frustration or generate headaches, eyesight issues, hearing loss, and even trauma or burnout.

It is worth noting that these core and contextual factors will, on occasion, also affect translators, interpreters and terminologists who are otherwise generally healthy and satisfied.

Bearing in mind cultural and location-specific differences, universities and other training institutes also have a role to play in educating future translators and interpreters on the growing importance of so-called soft skills as a means of responding and adapting to the changing working environment, such as flexibility, self-motivation, tolerance to ambiguity, and coping mechanisms. The paucity of training materials in these areas in the current curricula threatens the psychological sustainability of the next generation of professional linguists (Hubscher-Davidson, 2024). Tackling these aspects before students enter the workplace or before they engage in realistic assignments in the course of their studies could prepare them for what lies ahead.